

Sprint Retrospective Playbook

A compilation of proven inspection and adaptation formats for Scrum Masters and Agile teams.

CORE FORMATS OVERVIEW

1. Start-Stop-Continue

Best used when the team needs extreme clarity, operational simplicity, and immediate actionable process refinements.

2. The 4Ls Retro

Perfect for exploring underlying team emotions, tracking team learning, and boosting psychological safety/bonding.

3. Sailboat Framework

Excellent for high-level strategic alignment, predictive risk mapping, and unearthing external blockers or dependencies.

FORMAT 1: START • STOP • CONTINUE

This classic framework isolates immediate operational changes to streamline workflow execution without over-complicating discussions.

START

What should we begin doing?

- Practices or behaviors that will improve outcomes
- New engineering tools, automated tests, or techniques to try
- Direct tactical actions that actively support the Sprint Goal

STOP

What should we stop doing?

- Behaviors causing waste, unnecessary context-switching, or delivery delays
- Redundant meetings or legacy practices with no real value add
- Habits or anti-patterns that reduce focus or technical quality

 CONTINUE

What is working well?

- Core working agreements and practices consistently delivering real value
- Healthy team behaviors supporting transparent collaboration
- Technical standards and validation techniques that preserve quality

FORMAT 2: THE 4LS RETROSPECTIVE

Focuses heavily on the qualitative human elements of execution, helping team members process highlights, frustrations, and learnings.

LIKED

What did we enjoy during this Sprint?

- Positive milestones or rewarding moments
- Motivating interactions, peer support, or achievements

LEARNED

What new knowledge did we gain?

- Technical breakthroughs or domain insights discovered
- Surprises or unexpected variables navigated during development

LACKED

What was missing?

- Missing resources, context, requirements, or documentation
- Process elements or communication friction points that slowed us down

LONGED FOR

What do we wish we had?

- Support mechanisms, architectural tools, or environments needed
- Long-term structural adjustments to help the team excel

FORMAT 3: THE SAILBOAT RETROSPECTIVE

A highly visual metaphor that separates internal accelerators from forward-looking blockers and targeted architectural goals.

WIND

What is helping us move forward?

- Core team strengths and technical capabilities
- Supportive stakeholders and clear cross-team alignment
- Good engineering practices and robust deployment patterns

ANCHORS

What is slowing us down?

- Immediate operational impediments or environment downtime
- Unresolved cross-team dependencies or blocked pipelines
- Internal process issues, documentation lags, or technical debt

ROCKS

What risks lie ahead?

- Upcoming compliance or integration risks
- Potential technical blockers or unverified architecture designs

ISLAND

Where do we want to go?

- Core sprint objectives or long-term product vision metrics
- Desired engineering states, clean delivery outcomes, and team milestones

Scrum Master Tip

Great retrospectives don't come from fancy tools — they come from choosing the right format for the right situation. Mix templates regularly to keep engagement high and unearth hidden systemic blindspots.

For more Agile facilitation templates, interview prep, and real-world Scrum guidance, connect on LinkedIn and message **RETRO**.